Policies: Facilitator Guide

Business Academy Group Learning · Policies · May 2027

Session at a glance

In 60 minutes, providers review the policies that protect their program's income and relationships, identify gaps, and update one policy before summer.

Item	Detail
Month	May 2027
Audience	Business Academy providers, center-based and home-based
Length	60 minutes
Format	[In person / virtual]
Materials	Sample family handbook table of contents, sample tuition and illness policies, highlighters, printed Tips and Tricks sheet and Provider Handout
Ask providers to bring	Their current family handbook or policies, and staff handbook if they have one

Learning goals

By the end, each provider can:

1. List the core policies every child care business needs.
2. Find gaps or unclear wording in their own policies.
3. Rewrite one policy in clear, consistent language.
4. Plan how to share policy changes with families and staff.

Agenda

Time	Segment
0:00 – 0:05	Welcome and opener: "The policy I wish I'd had"
0:05 – 0:15	Why policies matter: fairness, income, and fewer conflicts
0:15 – 0:30	Core family and staff policies, and writing clear policies
0:30 – 0:45	Activity: Policy makeover
0:45 – 0:55	Implementation: your 30-day plan and one commitment
0:55 – 1:00	Takeaways and wrap-up

Why policies matter

Opener, "The policy I wish I'd had": Ask providers to share a situation that would have gone better with a clear written policy. Common answers: late pickups, unpaid tuition, sick children, holiday closures.

Talking points:

- **Policies protect relationships.** When rules are written ahead of time, hard conversations become "this is our policy," not personal.

- **Policies protect income.** Clear tuition, late fee, and closure policies prevent lost revenue.
- **Consistency is fairness.** Applying the same rules to everyone builds trust and reduces conflict.
- **Some policies are required.** Licensing standards require certain written policies; check yours.
- **Policies need updates.** A handbook written years ago may not match how the program runs today.

Core content: the policies that matter most

Policy area	What to cover
Tuition and payment	Rates, due dates, payment methods, late fees, nonpayment steps, rate change notice
Attendance and absences	Whether tuition is due for absences, vacation weeks, notice for withdrawal
Hours and late pickup	Hours of operation, late pickup fee, authorized pickup people
Closures	Holidays, weather, emergencies, and whether tuition changes
Health and illness	When children must stay home, return rules, medication
Behavior guidance	Your approach and how you partner with families
Communication	How and when you share updates; how families raise concerns
Staff policies	Schedules, time off, call-outs, pay schedule, conduct, training

Writing a clear policy

- **Use plain words.** Short sentences anyone can understand.
- **Be specific.** “Tuition is due every Monday by 6 p.m.” beats “Tuition is due weekly.”
- **Say what happens.** Include the consequence, such as a late fee or next step.
- **Get a signature.** Have families sign that they received and read the handbook.
- **Give notice of changes.** Share updates in writing with a clear start date.

This session is general guidance, not legal advice. Providers should check Virginia licensing standards for required policies and consult a professional for legal questions.

Implementation: your 30-day plan

Each provider leaves with one commitment and a 4-week plan; the Business Specialist checks progress at the next coaching session. Progress here also counts toward the pilot goal of at least one new or improved business practice per provider.

Week	Action	Done when
Week 1	Compare your handbook to the policy list; mark missing or outdated policies.	Gaps are marked
Week 2	Rewrite one priority policy in clear, specific language.	One policy is updated
Week 3	Check your policies against licensing requirements.	Required policies are confirmed
Week 4	Share the updated policy with families or staff in writing, with a start date.	Families or staff are notified

Tie-in to coaching

At the next individual coaching session, the Business Specialist will:

- ☐ Review the policy gap list
- ☐ Read the updated policy together for clarity
- ☐ Plan how and when to share changes
- ☐ Note any business practice change in the provider's progress record

Commitment card

Have providers fill this in before they leave and keep a copy:

- The policy I will update first: _____
- The gap I found: _____
- How I will share the change: _____
- The date the new policy starts: _____

Key takeaways

Close the session by reading these aloud; they also appear on the Provider Handout.

1. **Write it down.** Clear written policies prevent hard conversations.
2. **Be specific.** Dates, times, amounts, and what happens next.
3. **Apply it to everyone.** Consistency is what makes a policy fair.
4. **Check licensing.** Some policies are required, so make sure yours are covered.
5. **Review once a year.** Update policies as your program changes.

Activities and discussion

Activity: Policy makeover (15 minutes)

Give pairs a vague sample policy (for example, “Parents should pick up on time or there may be a fee”). They rewrite it to be specific: the exact time, the fee amount, how it’s charged, and what happens after repeated late pickups. Then each provider marks one of their own policies to rewrite.

Discussion questions

- Which policy causes the most conflict with families?
- Do you charge tuition for absences and vacations? How did you decide?
- How do you handle it when a family breaks a policy?
- How do you share policy changes so families actually read them?

Peer Connections prompt (May)

“Handbook and policy wins and headaches.” Providers share one policy that works well and one that keeps causing trouble. The group suggests wording or approaches for the headaches.

Handouts for this session

Walk through the **Policies Tips and Tricks** sheet during the content segment, and give out the **Policies Provider Handout** at the end.

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